The Shipwreck

6 November 1916. 11.25 a.m.

The passengers aboard the British steamer S.S. *Arabia* were savouring their pre-lunch soup and enjoying the bright sun on the deck. They were about 180 kilometres off Cape Matapan, at the end of the Mani Peninsula, Greece. It was a day after they had sailed from Port Said. The sea resembled glass.

Suddenly, without warning, a torpedo slammed into the side of the ship. It was the middle of the First World War, and the German navy was determinedly hunting down British ships using its modern fleet of U-boats. The German government maintained that the captain of the U-boat that fired the torpedo, Hans von Mellenthin, had considered the *Arabia* to be an 'auxiliary warship' from the 'attendant circumstances'.

This German torpedo would influence the future of the largest business conglomerate in India, the House of the Tatas, some eight decades later. For on the ship was the second son of the Tata Group's founder Jamsetji Tata, Sir Ratan Tata, the head of several undertakings of the group and a noted philanthropist, along with his wife Lady (Navajbai) Tata, his doctor, two secretaries and some other staff. A few months earlier, Sir Ratan had fallen ill and been advised to go to London for treatment. They were on their way when fate intervened.

As the torpedo had struck the fuel bunkers, the falling coal 'prevented the water coming in[to the ship] with a rush'. But the passengers and crew had to abandon ship. Sir Ratan and Lady Tata spent some hours on a lifeboat before being rescued by a fishing trawler. The shock and trauma of the incident worsened the already indisposed Sir Ratan's health. He eventually succumbed to his illness in St Ives, Cornwall, on 5 September 1918, about four months short of his forty-eighth birthday, leaving behind a fortune valued at £13,81,507 (currently equivalent to £6,21,30,309.45 or Rs 6,18,28,66,680) willing it to be used for the 'relief of human suffering or in works of public utility'.